

flimsy, and it required quite some effort just to insert a battery and put on the cover!

One of the most important things about any MP3 player are the earphones or headphones. The Apacer Audio Steno BP300 has cumbersome headphones with a bad finish. You can only use this MP3 player with the headphones for about a half hour before your ear starts aching.

The MSI MegaStick has the same kind of headphones bundled. The Creative, S-Media, Samsung and Sony earphones were the best that we listened to, especially the Sony and the Creative.

They not only scored well in the comfort department, but also provided excellent sound, although at very high levels the S-Media and the Samsung did show some distortion.

The last part is the portability factor. Almost all the players were quite light, except for the AudioSteno AP510, which was a bit bulky.

Performance

Performance is what finally matters. We played a variety of songs on each of the players and the response that some evoked was of pure pleasure, while others incited violence, with images of sledgehammers falling on them floating around our heads.

The Rhomba NX is a very good portable digital music player in terms of audio quality, and also acts as a pretty good portable storage system with USB 2.0 functionality. Similarly, the Samsung Yepp YP-T5 provided good audio quality results. The other mentionable players were the rest of the Creative players and the S-Media Butterfly.

In the area of portable storage, the AudioSteno AP220 acts as an extremely fast storage device; however, it is a mediocre MP3 player with the earphones only adding to its woes. On the other hand, the Sony is a very good player, but it comes with its own proprietary format called ATRAC, which is the only format the player will play.

So, if you want to transfer your MP3s or WMAs to the player, you will need to install the supplied SonicStage software, which will then convert the MP3s/WMAs to the ATRAC format, and then transfer them to the player.

This is cumbersome and sometimes unviable. The conversion and transfer takes a lot of time, and the format takes away the fun of using the player.

Moreover, the ATRAC files are not only transferred to the player but are also stored on the computer's hard drive, needlessly cluttering it up. This is a major disadvantage of the Sony Network Walkman and users will soon reject it outright.

The S-Media Butterfly is a very good quality MP3 player, but we encountered some skipping while browsing through the track list.

Voice recording was another test that we carried out in this category. The implementation on each player was different, but mostly varied between recording either in WAV (ADPCM) or MP3 formats. The recording quality of the Sony and the Creatives were the best, while the S-Media Butterfly fell flat in this department.

Buying Tips

Here are a few buying tips to help you make up your mind.

- ▶ First, check the interface of the player and the build quality. An intuitive interface and buttons are to be counted as a positive for any player.
- ▶ If your travelling includes a lot of bumps and jerks, do not opt for a hard drive-based solution, no matter how lucrative a deal you may be getting. A flash-based solution will be the right one for you. However, if your travelling is less stressful, a hard drive-based player would be a very good buy.
- ▶ Check the earphones. Flimsy earphones are a strict no-no. Try fitting the earphones in your ear and check the comfort level. If it feels even remotely irritating, do not buy the set.
- ▶ Check the claimed battery life of the player. If it is rated at 10 hours plus, that is a positive.
- ▶ In solid state players, check for features such as voice recording and FM recording. If it fits within your budget, check for the rest of the criteria.
- ▶ Check the number of formats that the player can support. The more the better.
- ▶ Finally, check all the possible places that you can for the player you like. Web sites such as www.amazon.com and www.ebay.com offer excellent deals, and you might just be lucky enough to get one!

In both the data transfer tests, which included a real-world and a synthetic SiSoft Sandra test, the Apacer AP220 blew away the competition. None of the other players could even come close. The other players' scores were quite in the same range when it came to either the USB 1.1 or USB 2.0 data transfer tests.

The last test involved battery life, and the Sony Network Walkman zoomed way ahead of the competition with a whopping battery life of 34 hours! If only this thing supported MP3s, you could go on a train journey and forget about the batteries for the player.

The Apacer AP510 followed the Sony with another whopping 21.5 hours of battery life—if only the player were a bit smaller! The Umax Draco again put in a bad performance, giving only 4 hours to a battery.

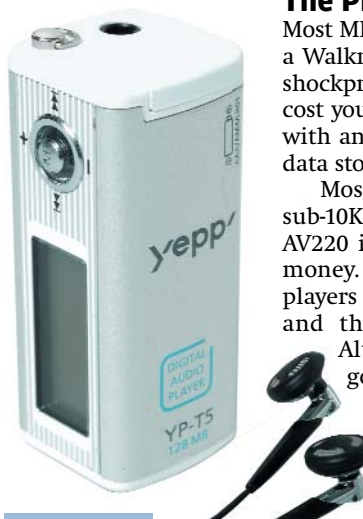
The ACi gives just an hour more than the Draco. The saving grace for the ACi is that it has an integrated rechargeable battery, and you can charge it using the accompanying USB cable.

The Price You Pay

Most MP3 players you get today cost the same as a Walkman did a few years ago. In fact, a good shockproof Discman from Panasonic or Sony will cost you just as much, and will not provide you with any of the functionalities such as portable data storage, FM recording or voice recording.

Most of the players that we received were sub-10K, and in fact, the Apacer Audio Steno AV220 is Rs 2,819, which is amazing value for money. Overall, the range of good quality MP3 players ranged between Rs 4,000 and Rs 7,000, and the functionalities ranged accordingly.

Although the Samsung players are pretty good in the performance and the audio quality departments, they simply do not justify the hefty price tags. The Transcend 256 MB is excellent for the price, since it offers you more data space, voice recording, and also plays WMA and MP3 files. The only things miss-



Samsung Yepp YPT5